

THE UNDERSTUDY

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Original work, bundled with Ripple

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demo-scripts/02-the-understudy

1 EXT. THE ALBION THEATRE - NIGHT 1

Manchester, 1931. Rain on a playbill under glass: THE WINTER WIDOW, and beneath it, in smaller type, MISS EVELYN ALDRIDGE.

A queue of wet umbrellas goes round the corner.

2 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 2

A row of gas footlights along the lip of the stage, each one hooded in brass, each one burning.

Behind them, a painted parlour. A woman in an emerald gown crosses to a window that opens onto nothing.

ANGLE ON - THE FOOTLIGHTS

One hood hangs loose on its bracket. The flame inside leans.

3 INT. ALBION THEATRE - PROMPT CORNER - NIGHT 3

Stage left, half a metre of floor and a shelf. VERA COYNE, 20s, holds the prompt book open with her thumb, mouthing every line a half-beat ahead of the actress.

She does not look at the page. She has not needed to for a month.

4 INT. ALBION THEATRE - WINGS - CONTINUOUS 4

STAGE MANAGER HOLLOWAY, 40s, clipboard, checks a watch against nothing.

HOLLOWAY

(low)

Where's her change?

VERA (O.S.)

Second interval.

HOLLOWAY

She's got ninety seconds.

VERA (O.S.)

She's had ninety seconds for four hundred performances.

5 INT. ALBION THEATRE - DRESSING ROOM ONE - NIGHT 5

Mirror bulbs, half of them out. EVELYN ALDRIDGE, 40s, holds herself very straight while a dresser works the hooks up the back of the emerald gown.

The gown is beaded to the shoulder. It weighs what a small child weighs.

EVELYN

Tighter.

DRESSER

It's at the last hook, Miss Aldridge.

EVELYN

Then move the hook.

6 INT. ALBION THEATRE - CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS 6

Vera passes the door with the prompt book under her arm. Slows. Doesn't stop.

7 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 7

Evelyn, in the emerald gown, delivers the curtain line to a house that has already begun to gather its coats.

CUT TO:

8 INT. ALBION THEATRE - PROMPT CORNER - NIGHT 8

Vera closes the prompt book. Rules a line under the date.

9 INT. PUBLIC HOUSE - NIGHT 9

Low ceiling. Company members crowded round two tables. Vera on the end of a bench, half in her coat.

DESMOND CARR, 30s, leading man, drops onto the bench beside her.

DESMOND

You were three words ahead of her all night.

VERA

Four, in the second act.

DESMOND

You were four ahead in the second act.

They both stop. Laugh.

10 INT. PUBLIC HOUSE - LATER 10

DESMOND

Ask Holloway for the Thursday matinee.

VERA

Holloway doesn't give matinees. Holloway gives notes.

DESMOND

Ask anyway.

11 INT. ALBION THEATRE - HOLLOWAY'S OFFICE - DAY 11

A desk, a safe, a schedule board. Holloway does not offer the chair.

HOLLOWAY

No.

VERA

I know the whole of it.

HOLLOWAY

Everyone knows the whole of it.
That's what a prompt book is for.

11A INT. ALBION THEATRE - HOLLOWAY'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS 11A

Vera puts the prompt book on the desk. Doesn't let go of it yet.

VERA

Then take it off me and give me the
Thursday.

Holloway looks at her hand on the book.

HOLLOWAY

Leave it there.

12 INT. ALBION THEATRE - CORRIDOR - DAY 12

Vera walks out with nothing under her arm. Her hand keeps closing on air.

13 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 13

Evelyn, in the emerald gown, misses a cue.

The pause runs two seconds long. Three.

VERA (O.S.)

(from the prompt corner, barely audible)
The window, Aunt Beatrice.

Evelyn crosses to the window.

14 MONTAGE - EIGHT PERFORMANCES 14

Evelyn late on a cue. Vera's mouth moving in the dark. The emerald gown going up on its hanger, coming down off its hanger, going up again.

The hood on the footlight, still loose.

END MONTAGE

15 INT. ALBION THEATRE - DRESSING ROOM ONE - NIGHT 15

Evelyn, out of the gown, in a robe, works cold cream across her face with both hands.

Her hands are not steady. She watches them until they are.

16 INT. ALBION THEATRE - WINGS - NIGHT 16

Desmond, in costume, waiting on his entrance. Vera beside him.

DESMOND

She's ill.

VERA

She's tired.

DESMOND

Those are the same word in this building.

17 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 17

CLOSE ON - the loose hood. The flame leans against the brass and blackens it.

A stagehand walks past it for the ninth night running.

18 INT. ALBION THEATRE - HOLLOWAY'S OFFICE - DAY 18

Holloway, on the telephone, writing nothing down.

HOLLOWAY

(into phone)

Then send whoever the agency has.
Tonight.

19 INT. ALBION THEATRE - GREEN ROOM - DAY 19

The company reads a notice pinned to the board. Nobody speaks.

Vera reads it twice.

20 INT. ALBION THEATRE - DRESSING ROOM TWO - NIGHT 20

Smaller mirror. Fewer bulbs. The emerald gown hangs on the back of the door, let out two inches at the waist.

Vera looks at it the way you look at a dog that might not know you.

DISSOLVE TO:

21 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 21

Vera, in the emerald gown, in the parlour that opens onto nothing.

She does not miss the cue.

22 INT. ALBION THEATRE - WINGS - CONTINUOUS 22

Holloway watches from the dark with the clipboard against his chest, not writing.

23 INT. PUBLIC HOUSE - NIGHT 23

The company, louder than usual. Vera in the middle of it for the first time.

DESMOND

To Thursday.

COMPANY

To Thursday.

24 INT. ALBION THEATRE - CORRIDOR - NIGHT 24

Evelyn, in a coat, walking out past the notice board. She does not read it.

She passes Vera in the corridor. Neither says anything.

25 INT. ALBION THEATRE - PROMPT CORNER - NIGHT 25

A YOUNG ASM, 19, holds the prompt book badly, thumb in the wrong place.

She loses her line. Finds it. Loses it again.

26 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 26

Vera covers the silence with a piece of business the play does not contain.

The house never knows.

27 INT. ALBION THEATRE - HOLLOWAY'S OFFICE - DAY 27

HOLLOWAY

You added four lines.

VERA
I added six.

HOLLOWAY
Don't do it again.

A beat.

HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
Do it again on Saturday if she drops
it again.

28 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 28

The emerald gown under the footlights. Vera turns downstage.
Behind her, the loose hood tips off its bracket and hangs by
one screw.

Nobody in the house looks at it.

29 INT. ALBION THEATRE - WINGS - CONTINUOUS 29

Holloway sees it. Starts forward. The scene is still running.
He stops.

30 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - NIGHT 30

The hood drops. The flame goes sideways into the painted
parlour flat.

Canvas takes light the way paper does.

30A INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - CONTINUOUS 30A

Vera turns into it. The beaded hem of the emerald gown goes
up first.

She gets two steps before Desmond hits her at the waist and
takes her down out of frame.

31 INT. ALBION THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - CONTINUOUS 31

Four hundred people stand at once. The house lights come up
on a room already full of smoke.

32 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - CONTINUOUS 32

Desmond rolls Vera in the safety curtain's weighted skirt.

The gown is gone from the knee down. Her right forearm, where
she put it out, is burned from wrist to elbow.

She is not making any sound at all.

FADE TO:

33 INT. HOSPITAL WARD - DAY 33

Rows of beds. Vera's right forearm dressed from wrist to elbow.

Desmond, in his own clothes for once, on a chair too small for him.

DESMOND
Holloway's saying the bracket was sound.

VERA
The bracket was loose in September.

DESMOND
I know.

VERA
You walked past it too.

34 INT. HOSPITAL WARD - LATER 34

Vera alone. She works the fingers of the right hand, one at a time, and gets three of them.

35 INT. ALBION THEATRE - STAGE - DAY 35

Daylight through the scene dock doors. The parlour flat is a black frame with nothing in it.

Vera walks the stage with her sleeve buttoned to the wrist over the dressing.

36 INT. ALBION THEATRE - HOLLOWAY'S OFFICE - DAY 36

The schedule board is wiped. The safe is open and empty.

HOLLOWAY
The company's dissolved as of Friday.

VERA
And the inquiry?

HOLLOWAY
There's no inquiry. There's an insurer.

37 INT. ALBION THEATRE - PROMPT CORNER - DAY 37

The prompt book on the shelf, cover scorched along one edge.

Vera picks it up left-handed.

38 EXT. THE ALBION THEATRE - DAY 38

The playbill case is empty. A bill-poster works a paste brush over the glass.

39 INT. REPERTORY THEATRE, LEEDS - AUDITION ROOM - DAY 39

A trestle table. Three people behind it. Vera in front of it, sleeve buttoned to the wrist.

CASTING WOMAN
And you've played the Widow.

VERA
Eleven times.

CASTING WOMAN
For Aldridge.

VERA
After her.

The casting woman looks at the sleeve. Vera unbuttons it and puts the arm on the table.

VERA (CONT'D)
Do you want the second act or the third?

FADE OUT.